Glossary

Al-Qaida From the Arabic word meaning a base (e.g. for training recruits in Afghanistan), it came to refer to an organisation, or a network, of Islamists of whom Osama Bin Laden was the leader. Responsible for the attacks on New York and Washington in 2001.

Anti-Semitism Feelings or actions showing prejudice or hatred towards the Jews.

Appease To make concessions in order to avoid conflict.

Arab Higher Committee A committee of Palestinian Arab leaders.

Arab League A body established in 1945 to represent the Arab states.

Arab Legion The army of Transjordan.

Arab nationalism A movement striving for Arab political unity.

Armistice An agreement to stop fighting.

Ayatollah Among Shia Muslims, the Ayatollahs are the most senior scholars, experts in interpreting the Koran.

Baath Means 'Renaissance' or rebirth of Arab power. The Baath Party had originally been established in Syria in the 1950s but its influence extended to several Arab countries.

Baghdad Pact An alliance formed by Britain, Turkey, Iran and, later, Pakistan and Iraq. Its headquarters were in the Iraqi capital of Baghdad.

Black September A Palestinian group which killed 11 Israeli athletes at the 1972 Olympics.

Blockade The blocking of a place or region by troops or ships to prevent goods or people reaching it.

Brinkmanship Pursuing a dangerous policy to the limits of safety.

Camp David The US President's mountain retreat.

Charisma The capacity to inspire devotion in others, as if endowed with superhuman or, at least, exceptional powers.

CIA The US Central Intelligence Agency, responsible for gathering information about foreign governments for the US government.

Coalition A union of two or more groups for a specific purpose.

Coalition Provisional Authority An organisation set up by the USA and its coalition allies to govern Iraq.

Cold War A state of tension, but not actual war, that existed between the USA and the Soviet Union between the late 1940s and late 1980s.

Coup Sudden or violent change of government.

'Crimes against humanity' Widespread or systematic attack against a civilian population.

Curfew A time or signal after which it was compulsory for people to remain indoors.

Diaspora The dispersal of Jews in many different parts of the world.

Eretz Israel The Land of Israel, as in the Bible. In effect, this meant the whole of